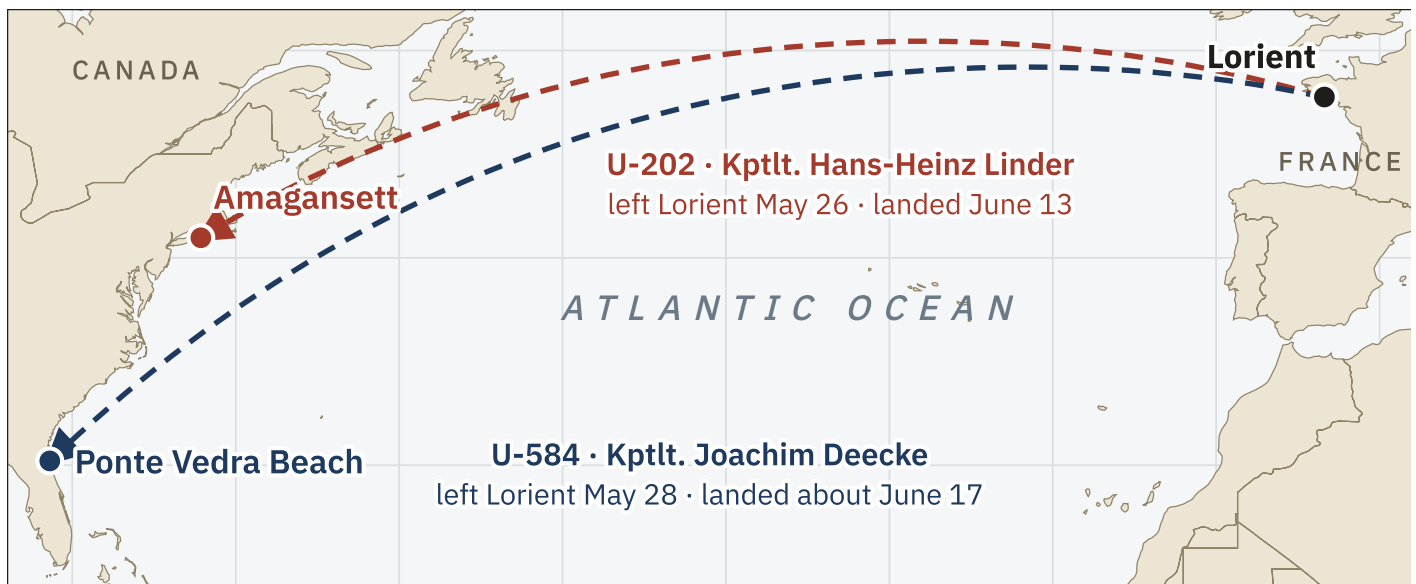


Operation Pastorius

Eight German saboteurs. Two beaches. One young Coast Guardsman with a flashlight, and sixteen days that ended the plot.



Long Island & Florida • June 1942

Large-print edition

Maps, the people, a minute-by-minute night on the beach, the court record, and a check of where the accounts disagree.

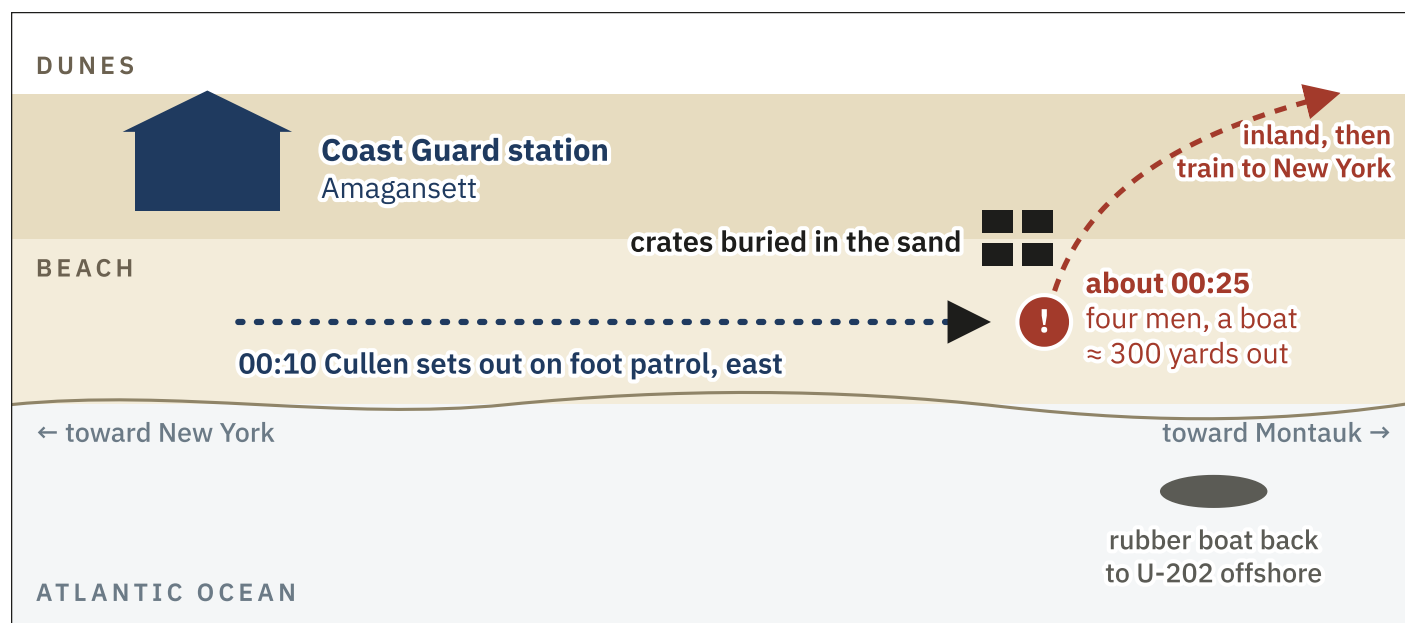
Amagansett, Long Island

The Long Island team landed about 100 miles east of Manhattan, near a Coast Guard station. From there they took a train to New York City.



Natural Earth coastline. The train line is sketched to show direction only.

On the beach (not to scale)



Sequence from the U.S. Navy's Eastern Sea Frontier war diary, June 1942. Positions are approximate.

John C. Cullen, 1920–2011

He was 21, a few months out of training, and armed with a flashlight and a flare gun. He had joined the Coast Guard a few weeks after Pearl Harbor.

Born in Manhattan on October 2, 1920, and raised in Queens, Cullen was one of the Coast Guard's "sand pounders," men who walked the beaches at night watching for exactly this. Just after midnight on June 13, 1942, in fog so thick he later said he could not see his own shoes, he made out a figure, then three more.

Their spokesman said they were fishermen who had run aground. One of them called out in German. The spokesman asked whether Cullen had a mother and father, said he would not want to have to kill him, and pushed money into his hand. The offer was \$300; when Cullen counted it later, it came to \$260.

Cullen took it, promised to forget their faces, and ran for the station. He did not forget. Shown photographs by the FBI, he picked out the man on the beach: George Dasch. He later identified Dasch again at the secret military trial in Washington.

Afterwards

- Awarded the Legion of Merit in 1943, a rare honor for an enlisted man.
- Toured war-bond drives and ship launchings as a Coast Guard hero.
- Left the service in 1946 as a Boatswain's Mate First Class and spent his career in the Long Island dairy business.
- Died in 2011, aged 90, in Chesapeake, Virginia.